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1 The scenic beauty of Gulmarg in Kashmir. Photo by Khalid Wani

2 The Lidder River flowing through Pahalgam Valley. Photo by Khalid Wani

3 Wani with one of his favourites, the Harley-Davidson Sportster

experiences over material possessions,” Wani says.

And yet, although his wanderlust has taken him to many destinations, Wani says that there’s no place better than Kashmir. He particularly highlights the Gurez Valley, a mere five to six hours from Srinagar, where the mesmerising emerald green Kishanganga river flows through the region.

“[It] is a spectacle that you need to witness once in your life and not to forget the small hamlets and villages in Gurez. It’s so peaceful there,” he says.

While Kashmir holds the top spot in Wani’s list, his second favourite riding destination is

the US. He fondly recalls the US as a dream destination for motorcyclists, boasting of numerous amazing destinations and routes that are waiting to be explored. Among his unforgettable experiences is a ride along the Californian coast, which includes traversing through Yosemite Park and visiting Lake Tahoe.

Wani finds biking trips even

WANI ASSERTS THAT THERE’S NO PLACE BETTER THAN KASHMIR FOR BIKING

more enjoyable when shared with close friends, enhancing the experience. “My preference is riding with a few friends, as it adds a wonderful social element to the journey. In fact, we have a tight-knit group called ‘Ride for Food.’ Our primary agenda is to explore new destinations while indulging in the quest for the best food joints around,” he says. Wani’s biking adventures are quite frequent, occurring once or twice a month, depending on the season. Each trip becomes a unique exploration, combining the thrill of biking with the joy of discovering hidden culinary gems. “The camaraderie within our group enhances the overall experience, turning every ride into a memorable and enjoyable event,” he adds.

But although he loves bikes in general, there is a special place in his heart for a Harley-Davidson and in his personal collection he owns a Sportster, a Roadking, and for the tougher terrains he rides on the Royal Enfield Himalayan at the moment. Now, he has his eyes set on the Harley-Davidson Pan America, which he rode when in the US.

“It’s too expensive an affair to transport my bike to every destination, so renting is the best way forward. Over the years I have experienced Triumph Tiger 900, Harley-Davidson Pan America, Harley-Davidson Street Glide, Royal Enfield 500 /350 and even those 100cc [bikes] for my trips across the Far East,” he says. But while riding a bike, be it in India or abroad, he insists on wearing a US-certified DOT (Department of Transportation) helmet and riding gear for his safety. Wani also carries his GoPro with 1TB of storage to capture the entire experience of his journey. **BT**

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